

GETTY IMAGES

Ram Gopal

(1912-2003)

Ram Gopal of Bangalore—half-Burmese, half-Rajput by lineage—helped put India's classical forms on the world map starting in the 1940s, through the 1960s. What Uday Shankar did for contemporary Indian dance, Ram Gopal did for classical. He learnt three forms—and once said, 'My left side is Bharatanatyam and the right side is Kathakali, in my legs lies Kathak.' Equipped with this trilingual flair, he created montages that made him look like a god dancing on stage. He was born to dance, and although he didn't leave many students, he mentored many. He left India for the UK in the 1960s.